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FUN, FANS AND FANATICS

ONE FINE day, I stopped partying. It became too much. I mean, think about it: I'm a sports star. I'm a decent-looking guy. I'm a Pathan. I'm Shahid Afridi. Obviously, things are going to happen while I'm partying, right? But I stopped it. I had to.

I enjoyed partying way too much, especially because I have a very addictive personality and I like the high of a good time (which comes naturally with the high of being a sportsman, I guess, and the constant adrenaline rush). But it's difficult to be a party animal in Pakistan. Especially the current state of Pakistan.

When we started out, there were no constraints on what we could or couldn't do. There was no social media – today, it compromises your social life. There weren't a lot of players who were religious. In fact, I started off with these superstar seniors who would kick us out of our hotel rooms, force us out, literally, and tell us to go and have some fun. As young players, we were blessed to have party animals as seniors. So, obviously, we partied. And boy, oh boy, we partied hard!

But I had to leave it. I loved it too much.

I didn't follow Imran Khan's pattern of being surrounded by superstars and socialites. But I did party, especially in my early days in the team. When I joined the team in the mid-1990s and the 2000s, we had a partying culture. Wasim bhai and Moin Khan were the leaders of the pack. We were expected to go out and not return to our rooms. It was essential, almost. Today, everybody fears the smartphone, for fear of being caught in a situation that could raise eyebrows.

I remember this one instance in Australia when we were on tour. We were in a nightclub one evening. All the guys were chatting up a girl each. I wasn't going to be left behind, so I found this real looker, a proper Melbourne girl. We chatted all night. We had a lovely evening. Upon parting, I told her I had to head to the airport in the morning to another city. She said she would come along and stay with me for the rest of the tour. Assuming she was joking, I told her, sure, why the hell not.